

UNCHAINED

TEXT: John 8:31-36 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, ‘If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.’³² And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”³³ They answered Him, ‘We are Abraham’s descendants, and have never been in bondage to anyone. How can You say, ‘You will be made free’?’”³⁴ Jesus answered them, ‘Most assuredly, I say to you, whoever commits sin is a slave of sin.’³⁵ And a slave does not abide in the house forever, but a son abides forever.’³⁶ Therefore if the Son makes you free, you shall be free indeed.”*

UNCHAINED FROM SIN

Unchained = To be made free from, or as if from chains.

It is to be:

- Exempt from external authority.
- Exempt from interference.
- Exempt from restriction.

Something to note - If we are bound with chains strong enough, they cannot be broken by us, they must be broken by a force beyond us.

When we are tightly bound by strong chains we require someone who has the physical power to break them! We stand in need of one who has the key/authority to loosen us from the chains of our sin!

Let me state it boldly and up front – The will of God is for us to be free – indeed! Jesus stated this fact twice in the same passage for emphasis sake – The first time he say’s “***Knowing the truth makes you free...***” Then He say’s closely

associating with the Son “*Makes us free* -

indeed...” Indeed - (Onywj – On’-Toce) = Really free – Actually free – Factually free. Sounds free to me! Who can be free? Those who know the truth (The Word) and those who are closely associated with the Son!

So how do we experience freedom from:

- Sin?
- Ourselves?
- Fleshly issues?
- Worldly issues?
- The expectations of others?

Step 1 – “***Know the truth***” – Become aware of what the Word has to say on the subject. One cannot become convicted of sin without knowing the truth about the sinfulness of that situation.

Step 2 – “*Continue in the Word*” - Real and lasting freedom is found in discipleship!

Discipleship is to abide ... Continue ... In His word ... Learning and applying it (Freedom Weekends & Life Groups)... The result of this interaction with His word is knowing truth ... Knowing the truth breaks the lies of Satan and exposes us to the person, will, and plan of God.

Step 3 – Close association with the Son... It is the process of discipleship that brings us into a close, personal, intimate relationship with the Son...

It's this success formula of (1) Knowing the Word... (2) Continuing in the Word... (3) Developing a personal relationship with Jesus that allows for the chains of sin to be truly broken from our lives!

Look at this Biblical example of being bound by sin and experiencing true freedom! Luke 8:26-27 ***“Then they sailed to the country of the Gadarenes, which is opposite Galilee. 27 And when He (Jesus) stepped out on the land, there met Him a certain man from the city who had demons for a long time. And he wore no clothes, nor did he live in a house but in the tombs.***

Look at the results of sin in this man’s life. This is a man who has literally lost everything ...

- His dignity... (clothes)
- His possessions... (house)
- His relationships... (family)
- His place among society... (community)

And this for a LONG TIME.

Reading this text begs the question: How did this man get into this condition of possession in the first place?

We don't have the particulars of his specific case, but we know that Satan gains entrance and exercises influence - and in the most severe cases such as this one, Satan wields complete control over one's life!

This kind of control is not relinquished in a moment of weakness, this occurs through long-term disobedience! We must be careful about continuing in long-term, willful sin! Every time we yield ourselves to willful sin we give up more and more control, and move closer and closer to allowing the enemy – not God – and not us - to be in control!

Those who operate in willful sin say things like, “*I’m not hurting anyone but myself*” – Don’t bet on it! The condition of this man not only affected him, it affected everyone around him!

Ephesians 2:1-3 “*And you He made alive, who were dead in trespasses and sins, 2 in which you once walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power (authority) of the air (spiritual atmosphere), the spirit who now works in (has influence upon) the sons of disobedience, 3 among whom also we all once conducted ourselves in the lusts of our flesh.*”

When we engage in willful sin, illicit relationships, occultic practices, witchcraft, drug and alcohol abuse, walking in intentional disobedience – each occurrence renders us less in control - and the enemy more in control!

Not all who sin become demon possessed, but all who sin are under the influence of spiritual darkness.

Look at the spiritual wantonness and depravity of the man named Legion! Luke 8:28-29

“When he saw Jesus, he cried out, fell down before Him, and with a loud voice said, “What have I to do with You, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? I beg You, do not torment me!” 29 For He had commanded the unclean spirit to come out of the man.”

Look at the warfare that was raging in this man as he came in his sinful condition into the presence of Jesus. The man is falling down in the presence of Jesus and begging for help – the demon is crying out not to be tormented!

Is this not the same struggle all of us have while we are in the process of being unchained from our sin?

- We know we need to be free – We don't know if we are ready to be free!
- We know we must make a change – But is now the time?
- We can clearly see where our path of sin is leading – Maybe another time would be better!
- Our sin has rendered us impotent – Yet, we cry out for one more night with the frogs!
(The vinedresser of the vineyard was ready to pull an unfruitful tree up and cast it in the fire but the owner of the vineyard said give it one more year!)

Legions condition:

- Broke the rules of social norms... “*The demons seized him and he broke the chains...*”
- Drove him out from society into the wilderness... He was homeless!
- Caused him to be feared rather than loved and respected...
- Robbed him of his potential, rendering him an outcast...

CONCLUSION:

In this state of possession this man could break physical chains - But he could not break spiritual chains! Hasn't this been true of all of us? Is this true of you today? Do you need an external force greater than you, to break your chains?

Legion needed the assistance of one stronger than his possessor! And he got it! And you can get it!

Listen to these beautiful words: Luke 8:34-35

“When those who fed them saw what had happened, they fled and told it in the city and in the country. 35 Then they went out to see what had happened, and came to Jesus, and found the man from whom the demons had departed, sitting at the feet of Jesus, clothed and in his right mind. And they were afraid.”

Here is what happened to Legion when the chains of sin were broken from him:

- His sanity regained...
- His dignity restored...
- His life and purpose renewed...

- He desired to follow Jesus... Jesus told him to go home and tell what had happened to him.
- His testimony influenced others... Luke 8:39 *“And he went his way and proclaimed throughout the whole city what great things Jesus had done for him.”*

UNCHAINED FROM RELIGION

John 8:31-36 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, “If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.”³² And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”³³ They answered Him, “We are Abraham’s descendants, and have never been in bondage to anyone. How can You say, ‘You will be made free’?”³⁴ Jesus answered them, “Most assuredly, I say to you, whoever commits sin is a slave of sin.”³⁵ And a slave does not abide in the house forever, but a son abides forever.”³⁶ Therefore*

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Unchained is to be:

- Exempt from external authority...
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For us to be unchained in any area of our lives, requires someone who has the physical power to break the chains... Or someone who has the key, or the authority to loosen us from the chains that bind or restrict us... Whether that is us, or someone, or something else, is predicated on the strength of the chains that have us bound!

If we are bound with chains strong enough, they must be broken by a force beyond us.

When I use the word religion today, I mean the man-made rules and rituals that others seek to enforce upon us, as the method which we are to employ in our effort of pleasing God:

- Religion is all about me... (What do I get out of this? What can I expect to receive? How does this benefit me?)
- Relationship is all about Him... (For His glory – In His honor – To please Him)

During His earthly ministry Jesus faced great opposition from the religious elite. One would think that when Perfect Truth entered the world that those who claimed to be about pursuing truth would embrace Him. But what we see is a horrible allergic reaction!

Among those religious elites was a sect called the Pharisees:

- They were called that, because they were not always Fair-You-See...
- Then there were the Sadducees... They were called that because they did not believe in the resurrection and that made them sad-you-see!
- The name Pharisee means, separated ones... You can see the problem arising here, right?
- They were well respected of the people because of their religious strictness... They were the holier-than-thou-crowd! No matter how holy one was or how many rules you could keep – They could always one-up-you!

But Jesus had a different opinion, He said of the Pharisees:

- They do not practice what they preach...
- They are hypocrites... (This is from the Greek language, indicating a play actor.

Actors wore masks to portray different parts.)

- They are all about the show... Their gift only worked when the red light was on – On the camera!
- They are tombs... (They look great on the outside but on the inside they are full of dead men's bones!)

Religion:

- Seeks to exalt self...
- Places the attention on MY works rather than MY RELATIONSHIP with Christ... (Relationship exalts the Savior. Relationship puts the attention on HIS works not mine!)
- Religion is self-righteous... (Places the emphasis on works rather than the finished work of the cross! The blood + nothing = Salvation!)

- Keep people out of heaven... (We become the gatekeepers) (I told one guy – “*You just make it to Heaven and I will show up and surprise you!*”)
- Perverts the true commands of God... (Adjusts God’s commandments to favor the rule makers and managers)
- Kills the spirit of true worshippers... (Randy & Joanna Lowe – “*Pastor, you need to do something about them!*” – My response – “*I’m not doing anything and neither are you!*”)

Religion condemns sinners and is happy about their condemnation! (Story of two preachers who preached on hell)

Jesus sought out the sinners to hang out with them and go to their houses! Why? Because He knew religion was why they were where

they were at, and only relationship could unlock them from their self-imposed prison of religion!

(Story of the Prodigal Son)

- Religion will seek to bind burdens of rules and rituals on you to get the Father's favor. ***“Father, I have sinned against heaven and in your sight, and am no longer worthy to be called your son.”***
- Relationship says, come on home! ***“But the father said to his servants, ‘Bring out the best robe and put it on him, and put a ring on his hand and sandals on his feet. 23 And bring the fatted calf here and kill it, and let us eat and be merry; 24 for this my son was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found.’ And they began to be merry.”***

Notice the reaction of the father:

- Joy... (Broadcast his son's return)
- Celebration... (Kill the fatted calf – Prepare a feast)
- Restoration... (Get a robe – Get a ring of son-ship)

Look at the reaction of the religious (Rule keeping) brother:

- He was angry... (Religion won't just make you angry – It will make you mean!)
- Refused to attend the celebration...
(Religion will help you to paint yourself on the outside of the celebration of the Father's celebration!) (My response to someone who said *"Can you imagine what this church would be if we had everyone who has left and all the people who have become a part of CT?"* I said, *"Some of you couldn't be here is some of them had stayed!"*)

- Was offended that his brother – rather than him – Was being celebrated... (This wasn't the celebration of the son – This was the celebration of the Father! - The Father can celebrate who He wants to!)

CONCLUSION:

The conclusion of this matter is that religion is diametrically opposed to the heart of God:

- Religion is exclusive – The Father is inclusive! “... *That whosoever believes in Him...*”
- Religion seeks to restrict – The Father seeks to break the chains... “*You shall know the truth – the truth shall make you free.*” “*He that the son sets free is free indeed.*”
- Religion seeks to discredit – The Father seeks to empower... “*Come now and let us reason together say's the Lord...*”

- Religion tries to alienate people – The Father attempts to draw everyone nearer...
“Draw me nearer, nearer, nearer blessed Lord.”

UNCHAINED FROM THE EXPECTATION OF OTHERS

John 8:31-36 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, “If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.”³² And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”³³ They answered Him, “We are Abraham’s descendants, and have never been in bondage to anyone. How can You say, ‘You will be made free’?”³⁴ Jesus answered them, “Most assuredly, I say to you, whoever commits sin is a slave of sin.”³⁵ And a slave does not abide in the house forever, but a son abides forever.”³⁶ Therefore*

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In this series we have talked about being

unchained:

- From sin...
- From brokenness...
- From religion...

Today we are going to talk about how the actions and expectations of others have a profound impact upon our lives. Words and actions have consequences for good and for bad. Words and actions have the power to build one up, and words and actions have the power to tear one down. ***“Life and death is in the power of the tongue.”***

I want to use a beautiful Old Testament story of privilege, tragedy, and grace to illustrate my point today. (2 Samuel 9)

The setting for this story is initiated in a friendship between Jonathan, the son of Saul, and David, a shepherd transitioning to King!

When Saul the first King of Israel, sinned against the Lord, the prophet came to the house of Jesse and anointed David to be the successor of Saul. Saul eventually becomes jealous of David and tries to kill him. It was through these treacherous circumstances that David forged a strong relationship with Jonathan, Saul's son.

Through a violent battle with his archenemy, the Philistines, Saul was deposed as King and he and his sons were killed in that very battle.

Remember, ***“Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall.”***

As a matter of course, when a King was deposed in the manner that Saul was, his entire family line was to either be killed or exiled. In addition, all of their wealth was to become the property of the successor, or, of the nation itself.

When Saul was defeated, David began to rule over Judah and reigned for seven years and six

months, at which time he began presiding over the entire nation and moved his governmental headquarters to Jerusalem. In the process of time David decided to find out whether there were any descendants of the house of Saul who remained. In his busyness of being King, David had lost touch with all who remained from the house of Saul, so he asked his servant Ziba to find out if anyone from Saul's family line had survived.

Ziba revealed to David that there was a lone descendent of the house of Saul. His name was Mephibosheth and he was the son of Jonathan and the grandson of Saul.

Mephibosheth was once a prince facing life in the privilege of the palace, and maybe even ascending to the throne himself one day! The expectations of others were running pretty high! Everyone expected Mephibosheth to live out his life in the lap of luxury.

At the age of five everything changed for Mephibosheth. His father, Jonathan, and his grandfather Saul were killed in a battle against the Philistines. When this occurred the expectations and actions of others turned on a dime, as they often do. One can go from a hero to a haint in a matter of minutes.

When the nanny who was caring for Mephibosheth heard of the tragic results of the battle between the Israelites and Philistines she picked up five-year-old Mephibosheth, and made a run-for-it. In her haste to flee, she dropped the child and he suffered a spinal injury. In one tragic day, at the age of five Mephibosheth:

- Lost his mobility...
- Lost his position as a prince...
- Lost a very influential grandfather...
- Lost a father who no doubt adored him...
- Lost his ability to make a living because of his injury...
- Lost the security of being protected as a result of his family name...

Not only did Mephibosheth lose all of these things, Ziba revealed that he was living in the house of Machir, in Lo Debar. Interestingly enough, Machir is the brother of Bathsheba!

Machir, the son of Ammiel resided in Lo Debar:

- The name Ammiel comes from a Hebrew word meaning, “*People of God.*”
- The word Machir comes from the Hebrew word, “*makik*” (maw-kak) meaning “*To be brought low – decaying.*” The place Lo Debar was a pasture-less place in Palestine, probably desert and therefore more than likely it was a poverty-stricken place.

Notice the sad trajectory of this once promising family with whom Mephibosheth was living:

- At one time they were the people of God...
- They had been brought low...
- They were living in a poverty-stricken place...

If that is not bad enough, Mephibosheth was living with them, and had become completely reliant on their mercy and resources! If they were in a dreadful spot in their lives, Mephibosheth was in an even worse position!

The expectations for Mephibosheth's life had changed from power, prestige and prominence; to poverty, pity and even pathetic.

When we allow ourselves to be driven by the expectations and actions of others we tend to live up to, or down to, their expectations! As a result of the expectations of others:

- Some of you are underachieving because of the words that have been spoken over you...
- Some of you do not believe you can climb out of the vicious cycle that has plagued your family...
- Some of you believe you are going to have to live in poverty the rest of your life, because that is the way it has been for generations in your family...

- Some of you believe you can't start that business that you have in your heart, because of the fear imposed upon you by someone else...
- Some of you are in a career that you did not choose, it was chosen for you, and someone is living their life vicariously through you...
- Some of you feel trapped in a relationship that was not of your choosing...
- Some of you believe you are going to suffer with a certain disease because you were told that the disease "*Runs in the family...*"
- Some of you don't believe you can be involved in ministry because of a past failure...

I am here to tell you today that everything is not as it seems or as it has been stated! God is able to turn the tables on the enemy!

This is where the story of Mephibosheth begins to turn!

Others may not know we are alive and in the condition we are in, but God the Holy Spirit does! If we will allow the Holy Spirit to get involved in our devastating situation, He WILL unchain us from the expectations of others!

Because of what others did, the pattern for Mephibosheth seemed to be:

- One failure after another...
- Frustrations that built one upon another...
- Dashed dreams that appeared to be forever gone...
- Disillusionments that appeared impossible to resolve...
- Disappointments that remained unsettled year after year...

God was about to unchain Mephibosheth from the actions and words of others and He is going to do the same for some others in this room today!

David didn't owe Mephibosheth anything neither did God owe us anything. If David did not owe Mephibosheth anything why would he give him a second thought? 2 Samuel 9:1 (NKJV) ***“David said, “Is there still anyone who is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan’s sake?”*”**

Every act of kindness and generosity from David to Mephibosheth was for Jonathan's sake! David searched Mephibosheth out with intentions of blessing, because of his relationship with Jonathan.

None of us deserve to be loved or blessed by God! God has decided to love us and show us His kindness for Jesus' sake! God is going to unchain us from the actions and words of others for Jesus sake! Titus 3:5 (MESSAGE) ***“It wasn't so long ago that we ourselves were stupid and stubborn, dupes of sin, ordered every which way by our glands, going around with a chip on our shoulder, hated and hating back. But when*”**

God, our kind and loving Savior stepped in, he saved us from all that. It was all his doing; we had nothing to do with it. He gave us a good bath, and we came out of it new people, washed inside and out by the Holy Spirit. Our Savior Jesus poured out new life so generously. God's gift has restored our relationship with him and given us back our lives. And there's more life to come—an eternity of life! You can count on this.

When David sent for Mephibosheth, it never occurred to Mephibosheth that the King might have summoned him for the purpose of doing him good rather than evil.

Because of years of living in hopelessness Mephibosheth assumed nothing good could befall him. Once hope is lost, self-destructive behavior sets in. When one begins to participate in self-destructive behavior:

- Blessings are turned to rubbish through negligence... (One may not have the best car in

the neighborhood but it should at least be kept clean)

- Opportunities are obscured by pessimistic behavior... (When personal expectations are that nothing good is going to happen, one tends to miss any opportunity for success)
- The prospect of improved conditions becomes clouded by skepticism... (When one allows his/her behavior to be clouded with sarcasm, the chances of the circumstances improving by any measureable increment is slim to none)

Thomas Jefferson said, "I like the dreams of the future better than the history of the past."

Will we allow our past and present circumstances to determine our future success?

Wendy Wasserstein said, "Don't live down to expectations. Go out there and do something remarkable."

King David revealed his intentions to Mephibosheth! David was intent on placing

Mephibosheth in a position of being blessed by the King and the Kingdom!

Father God has sent the High Sheriff of Heaven (The Holy Spirit) to CT Church to arrest (Convict) us today, not to bring us to justice but to reposition us for blessing! Will we allow the actions and words of others to dictate what our future is going to look like?

We can keep living in a poverty-stricken, sin-infested, self-destructive, downward spiraling, and hopelessly depressing position if we choose to do so, or we can cast those words and actions down and become what God has designed for us to be.

While Mephibosheth was languishing in the house of Machir in Lo Debar:

- God was placing sticky notes in the mind of David concerning his relationship with Jonathan...

- God was texting Ziba thoughts of the plight of the lame son of Jonathan...
- God was e-mailing Ziba the googleeearth position of the only known survivor of the house of Jonathan...
- God was positioning Ziba to be the trusted servant of David...
- God was influencing the heart of Machir to be willing to share his resources with Mephibosheth until God was ready to relocate him to the palace...

Though deliberate, the plan of God was brilliant in the life of Mephibosheth! This plan included:

- Rescue from living in a poverty-stricken desert place...
- Being brought into the presence of the King of the land...
- The kindness of the King and Kingdom being demonstrated in his life...
- Restoration of all the wealth of his father and grandfather...

- Assigning Ziba, his 15 sons and twenty servants to become custodians of all the property that had been returned to Mephibosheth...
- Eating every meal at the Kings table... Living in the palace, never to return to the house of Machir in Lo Debar...

CONCLUSION:

Despite the actions and words of others God's plan for us includes:

- Rescuing us from the poverty-stricken desert of sin...
- Being repositioned for a fruitful future rather than wallowing in the pain of past experiences...
- Being made partakers of His divine nature...
- Restoration of the years that have been stolen by fruitless living...
- Becoming connected to people who can assist us in achieving our life purpose...
- Dining continually at the table of the King...

I want to conclude my thoughts here with a quote from Meister Eckhart - *“For however devoted you are to God, you may be sure that he is immeasurably more devoted to you.”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**

7/2018